First Aid and Emergency Warning Signs

What to do in common emergencies, and when to call for help

1. When to call emergency services

Emergency numbers in India: call 112, the national emergency number, or call 102 or 108 for an ambulance, depending on your state. Call straight away for chest pain, difficulty breathing, signs of a stroke, severe bleeding, unconsciousness, a seizure that does not stop, a serious burn, poisoning, or a severe allergic reaction. Do not wait to see if it improves.

What to tell the operator: say where you are, what happened, how many people are hurt, and whether the person is awake and breathing. Stay on the line and follow the instructions you are given.

2. Heart attack warning signs

Symptoms of a heart attack: pressure, squeezing or tightness in the chest that lasts more than a few minutes, pain spreading to the arm, shoulder, neck, jaw or back, shortness of breath, cold sweat, nausea and light-headedness. Women, older people and people with diabetes may have milder or unusual symptoms such as unusual tiredness or indigestion-like discomfort.

What to do for a suspected heart attack: call emergency services immediately, keep the person sitting down and calm, loosen tight clothing, and do not let them drive. Do not give food or drink. Give medicine only if the emergency operator or the person's doctor has told them to use it. If the person becomes unconscious and is not breathing normally, start CPR if you are trained.

3. Stroke warning signs (FAST)

How to recognise a stroke with FAST: F is for Face drooping on one side, A is for Arm weakness or numbness, S is for Speech that is slurred or confused, and T is for Time to call emergency services at once. Other signs are sudden severe headache, sudden trouble seeing, loss of balance and sudden confusion.

What to do for a stroke: note the time the symptoms started, because treatment works best within the first few hours. Keep the person safe and still, and do not give food, drink or medicine.

4. Burns

First aid for burns: move away from the heat source and cool the burn under cool running water for at least 20 minutes. Remove rings, watches and tight clothing near the burn before it swells. Cover the burn loosely with a clean non-fluffy cloth or cling film.

What not to do with a burn: do not apply ice, butter, toothpaste, oil or ointments, and do not burst blisters.

When a burn needs urgent care: go to hospital for burns that are large, deep, on the face, hands, feet or genitals, caused by chemicals or electricity, or any burn in a baby or an older person.

5. Cuts and bleeding

First aid for bleeding: wash your hands if you can, then press firmly on the wound with a clean cloth or bandage and keep pressing. Raise the injured part above the level of the heart if possible. If blood soaks through, add more cloth on top rather than removing the first one.

When bleeding is an emergency: call emergency services if bleeding is heavy, spurting, or does not stop after 10 minutes of firm pressure, or if the wound is deep, from an animal bite, or contains a foreign object. A tetanus shot may be needed for dirty or deep wounds, so ask a doctor.

6. Sprains and strains

First aid for a sprain: rest the injured part, apply a cold pack wrapped in cloth for 15 to 20 minutes every few hours, gently wrap it with a bandage for support, and keep it raised.

When to see a doctor for a sprain: get medical help if the area looks deformed, you cannot put weight on it, the pain is severe, or it is not improving after a few days, because it may be a fracture.

7. Nosebleed

First aid for a nosebleed: sit upright and lean slightly forward. Pinch the soft part of the nose firmly for 10 minutes without letting go. Do not tilt your head back. Breathe through the mouth.

When a nosebleed needs a doctor: seek medical help if bleeding continues after 20 minutes, follows a head injury, or happens often.

8. Choking

First aid for choking in an adult: if the person can cough, encourage them to keep coughing. If they cannot breathe, cough or speak, give up to 5 firm back blows between the shoulder blades, then up to 5 abdominal thrusts (Heimlich manoeuvre). Keep alternating and call emergency services. Taking a certified first aid course is strongly recommended, and choking in babies needs a different method.

9. Heat exhaustion and heatstroke

Signs of heat exhaustion: heavy sweating, weakness, dizziness, headache, nausea and cold, pale, clammy skin. Move the person to a cool, shaded place, loosen clothing, apply cool wet cloths and give small sips of water.

Signs of heatstroke: a body temperature above 40 degrees C, hot dry or flushed skin, confusion, fainting or seizures. Heatstroke is an emergency, so call emergency services and cool the person quickly with wet cloths and fanning while waiting for help. During hot weather, drink plenty of water, avoid going out at midday and wear light clothing.

10. Severe allergic reaction (anaphylaxis)

Signs of anaphylaxis: swelling of the face, lips or throat, difficulty breathing or wheezing, widespread hives, dizziness or fainting, and vomiting soon after exposure to a food, insect sting or medicine.

What to do for anaphylaxis: call emergency services immediately. If the person has a prescribed adrenaline auto-injector, help them use it. Lay them flat with legs raised unless they are struggling to breathe, in which case let them sit up.

11. Snake bite and poisoning

First aid for snake bite: keep the person calm and still, keep the bitten limb still and at about heart level, remove rings and tight items, and get to a hospital with antivenom immediately. Do not cut the wound, suck out venom, apply a tight tourniquet or use home remedies.

First aid for poisoning: call emergency services or go to the nearest hospital straight away and take the container or substance with you. Do not make the person vomit and do not give anything to drink unless a medical professional tells you to.

Important: this document gives general first aid information and is not a substitute for professional medical care or a first aid course. In any emergency, call 112 or your local ambulance number first.